

Social Studies - Guide to Analysing Sources

What is the purpose of a social studies source analysis?

- To demonstrate your knowledge of the Social Studies curriculum in a sophisticated and organized manner

How?

- Analyze three sources and demonstrate an understanding of the perspective(s) reflected in each source and their relationship to a particular topic (i.e. globalization, nationalism, liberalism)
- Establish a relationship between the three sources

How to Analyze a Quotation

Explain the source

1. Discuss any background or contextual information that is important to understand the quotation. For example:
 - who is the author? where is he/she from?
 - the author's political, economic, and/or social views
 - important events that may have shaped his/her perspective
2. What is the message, intent, or purpose of the author/speaker without repeating the source?
3. 2-3 sentences "describing the meaning" of the quotation, as it relates to your topic

Identify the perspective

1. What terms, concepts, or ideas are involved?
2. Does the author accept or reject any terms, concepts or ideas?
3. Is there bias?

Provide Support

- Use direct quotations, facts from the source to support your interpretations

How to Analyze a Political Cartoon

Review the entire cartoon, identify what you know

- ☐ What is your first impression?
- ☐ What terms, symbols, and concepts are involved?

Satire: criticizing an idea or perspective

- ☐ MAKE SURE YOU IDENTIFY the idea or perspective that is being criticized
- ☐ What background information is relevant?
- ☐ Historical context

Identify and explain techniques

- ☐ Labeling, exaggeration, analogy, symbolism, irony
- ☐ What is the overall message and how it relates to the topic (globalization, nationalism, liberalism)

Provide support for your interpretations

How to Analyze a Picture

Explain the Picture

- ☐ Describe important details of the picture (1-2 sentences)
- ☐ Discuss any background or contextual information that is necessary in order to understand the picture
- ☐ 2-3 sentences "describing the meaning" of the picture, as it relates to your topic

Identify the perspective

- ☐ What terms, concepts or ideas are involved?
- ☐ Does the picture appear to support or reject any terms, concepts or ideas?

Provide Support

- ☐ Use specific references to aspects of the picture to support your interpretations

How to Analyze Graphs, Tables, Statistics, Maps and Charts

- ☐ Describe important details presented in the source (1-2 sentences)
- ☐ What is on the X and Y axis?
- ☐ What is being compared/contrasted?
- ☐ Discuss any background or contextual information that is necessary in order to understand the source
- ☐ 2-3 sentences "describing the meaning" of the picture, as it relates to your topic (i.e. globalization, nationalism, or liberalism)
- ☐ What conclusions can be drawn from the information?
- ☐ What possible trends can you predict from this information?
- ☐ Use specific references to aspects of the sources to support your interpretations

Explaining relationships**What relationship exists among all the sources?**

- ☐ To which aspect of globalization, nationalism, or liberalism are all sources connected?
- ☐ Consider terms and concepts, and try to find:
 - spectrums and ideas that can be compared or different types of a particular idea.
- ☐ Must discuss AT LEAST ONE COMMON RELATIONSHIP
- ☐ Compare and contrast: find similarities and differences between the sources
- ☐ Is there a cause/effect relationship among the sources?
- ☐ Identify common themes and/or overarching issues
- ☐ Identify an essential question each source addresses
- ☐ Do not simply restate your impression of the sources. Offer new insight!!

Provide Support

- ☐ How do you know that the source illustrates a particular perspective?

Things not to do in your paper!

- ☐ Do not critique or give your opinion on the source. You are only meant to analyze the source (you will get your chance to give your opinion in a position paper)
- ☐ Do not make claims/assumptions that cannot be supported

Format

- ☐ Include a title. If you cannot think of one, use the question provided
- ☐ A brief introduction--1-2 sentences
- ☐ Paragraph 1: analysis of source 1
- ☐ Paragraph 2: analysis of source 2
- ☐ Paragraph 3: analysis of source 3
- ☐ Paragraph 4: explain the relationship